

■ PLANT LIVING DATABASE

Complete User Guide

A plain-language guide to every feature: searching, filtering, cloud sync, and more.

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1

The Interface — Finding Your Way Around

The Plant Living Database runs entirely in your web browser — no installation required. Open the file or hosted URL and it is ready to use. Your data saves automatically between sessions.

Navigation Bar (top of screen)

Seven tabs across the top switch between sections:

- **Plant Database** — Main working area — search, filter, view cards, add plants.
- **Introduction** — Reference resources and links for plant selection.
- **Tree Selection Criteria** — Alphabetical checklist for urban tree assessment.
- **Field Reference** — All dropdown options for every field listed for quick lookup.
- **Phenology Calendar** — Month-by-month flowering and fruiting calendar.
- **Dashboard** — Live charts, AI description generator, and suitability checker.
- **Sync** — Connect to Google Sheets for cloud sync across all devices.

Key Controls

Hero Banner	Database statistics and save indicator. Green dot = saved, orange = saving.
Download PD.zip	Download the database files (index.html, plantdatabase.html, manifest.json, sw.js, Code.gs, icons/).
Search bar	Searches all text fields: name, genus, family, description, notes, tags.
Filters button	Opens the advanced filter panel with 8 multi-select pill fields plus dropdowns and ranges.
Sort dropdown	Order results by name, genus, height, date added, modified, or photo count.
■ / ≡ toggle	Switch between card grid view and compact list/table view.
Photo bar	Set card photo height, fit mode, gallery columns. Also holds Compare and Collections.
Batch Edit	Activates batch selection mode to edit multiple plants at once.
Import / Export / + Plant	Action buttons above the card grid.
Appearance (■)	Customise themes, colours, card density, grid columns, and nav style.

Searching and Filtering (Advanced Filter Panel)

All filters update the card grid instantly. Click the **Filters** button above the card grid to open the advanced filter panel. Active filters show as dismissible colour chips in the bar next to the Filters button.

Filter Sections

- **Identity & Classification** — Plant Type, Life Cycle, Origin (multi-select pill toggles), Life Expectancy (dropdown).
- **Growing Conditions** — Climate Zone, Aspect / Light, Soil Type (multi-select pill toggles), Site Constraint (dropdown).
- **Dimensions** — Height min–max (metres) and Width min–max (metres). Both bounds are now independent.
- **Botanical Characteristics** — Flower Colour, Flowering Season (multi-select pill toggles), Native Region (free text).
- **Uses & Ecology** — Uses, Supports Wildlife, Ecological Role (all dropdowns).
- **Health, Safety & Status** — Weed / Invasive Status, Allergen Risk, Toxic Parts, Health Status (all dropdowns).
- **Catalogue** — Custom Tag, Collection, Has Photos (dropdowns).

Multi-select pill fields (Plant Type, Climate Zone, Aspect, Soil, Life Cycle, Origin, Flower Colour, Flowering Season) let you select multiple values at once. Tapping a pill toggles it green/selected. Within each field, any selected value matches (OR logic). Across fields, the AND/OR setting at the bottom of the panel applies.

Filter Logic & Active Chip Bar

ALL filters (AND)	A plant must match every active filter to appear.
ANY filter (OR)	A plant matching any one active filter appears.
Active chip bar	Shows each active filter as a chip. Click X on any chip to remove just that filter.
X Clear all	Removes all filters and resets the panel to default state.

Saved Searches

Set up your filters, click + Save search above the filter panel, and type a name. The search appears as a teal pill for instant recall. Click X to delete.

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Adding a New Plant

Click the green **+ Plant** button above the card grid. At minimum, enter either a Genus or a Common Name to save. The form is organised into sections:

Standard Fields

Family, Genus *, Species	Taxonomy. Genus or Common Name is required.
Subspecies, Variety, Cultivar	Further taxonomic subdivision and cultivar notes.
Common Name/s *	Displayed prominently on the card.
Height / Width (M)	In metres. Ranges accepted, e.g. 2–4.
Plant Type 1 / 2 / 3	Type 1 = growth form. Type 2 = life cycle. Type 3 = origin.
Life Expectancy	Approximate lifespan from the dropdown.

Multi-Select Fields — Click Pills to Toggle

Climate Type/s, Aspect/Light, Soil/Media Preferences, and Site Constraints all use clickable pill grids. Click any option to select it (turns green). Select as many as apply.

Botanical Characteristics

- Leaf Type/Shape
- Flower Colour — 12 colours, multi-select
- Flowering Season/s — multi-select
- Fruit/Seed Description, Fruiting Period — multi-select
- Native Region — free text (e.g. VIC, NSW, Eastern Australia)

Uses & Ecology

- Uses — 20 options, multi-select
- Supports Wildlife — 11 options, multi-select
- Ecological Role — 12 options, multi-select
- Indigenous Uses/Notes — free text

Other Fields

Health, Safety & Status	Toxic/Poisonous Parts, Allergen Risk, Weed/Invasive Status, Plant Health Status.
Location Data	GPS Coordinates (decimal degrees), Map Reference/Grid.
Description & Cultural Requirements	Free text for features, maintenance, and growing notes.
Custom Tags	Type a keyword and press Enter or comma. Used for flexible filtering.
Notes	Private scratchpad for personal observations.
Collection	Assign to one of your named collections.
Photos	Click Add Photos to upload images. First photo becomes the cover.

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Viewing a Plant Profile & Print Profile

Click any plant card to open its full profile. Scroll down to see all sections. The action buttons at the bottom are:

CSV	Immediately downloads a CSV for this one plant.
PDF	Generates a detailed PDF profile for this plant.
Print (new)	Prints a clean A4 profile card for this plant using your browser's print/PDF dialog. Click the Print button in the top-right corner of the profile header.
— Edit	Opens the edit form pre-filled with all data.
Label	Opens the plant label and QR code generator.
Duplicate	Creates a copy and opens it in the edit form.
Log	Opens the planting journal for this plant.
Delete	Removes this plant. An Undo toast appears for 8 seconds.

Print Profile

The **Print** button in the top-right of the profile header generates a clean A4 printable sheet covering all plant data: taxonomy, growing conditions, botanical characteristics, uses & ecology, health & safety details, notes, and tags. A weed/invasive warning banner appears prominently if the plant has a weed status. Use your browser's "Save as PDF" option to create a PDF file.

Weed / Invasive Badge (card view)

Plant cards now show a red badge in the top-right corner if the plant has a weed or invasive status. Noxious declared plants pulse gently to draw attention. The badge text abbreviates the full status for space.

The profile also shows a  Look Up Online section near the bottom with 13 one-click links to external databases (see Section 13). If GPS coordinates are recorded, an embedded Google Maps view appears with Open in Maps and Get Directions buttons.

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Managing Photos

Each plant can have any number of photos. The first photo is always the cover — shown on the card and at the top of the profile.

Adding photos	From the form — scroll to Photos and click Add Photos. From the profile — click + Add Photos above the photo strip.
Edit (hover)	Opens the Photo Editor for non-destructive adjustments: rotate, scale, offset, flip, caption.
Set as Cover	Promotes this photo to the first/cover position.
Delete	Removes this photo from the plant.

■ Storage tip

Resize images to ~1200px wide before uploading. Large photos fill browser storage quickly. If storage fills, export a JSON backup which includes all photos encoded.

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Editing, Duplicating, and Deleting Plants

Editing	Open a plant profile and click — Edit. Every field is editable. Last Modified date updates automatically when you save.
Duplicating	Click Duplicate in any plant profile. A copy is created with "(Copy)" appended to the common name. The edit form opens immediately.
Deleting	Click Delete. After confirming, an Undo toast appears for 8 seconds. Click Undo to restore instantly.

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Batch Edit — Editing Multiple Plants at Once

1

Click Batch Edit

Blue tick-boxes appear on every card.

Select plants

Click the tick-box on each plant to include.

3

Choose an action

Edit Field, Set Collection, Add Tag, or Delete All from the blue bar at top.

Exit

Click X Cancel or click Batch Edit again.

Edit Field	Choose a field (Type, Life Cycle, Life Expectancy, Weed Status, Health Status, Native Region) and a new value.
Set Collection	Assign all selected plants to a collection in one step.
Add Tag	Add a tag to all selected plants at once.
Delete All	Delete all selected plants. Undo available for 8 seconds.

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Planting Log / Journal

Every plant has a private journal where you can record timestamped observations, maintenance actions, health updates, and planting events.

Opening the Log	Click Log in any plant profile. Entries appear in reverse chronological order.
Adding an entry	Select a type (Observation, Maintenance, Health Update, Planting), set a date, write your entry, click + Add Entry.
Deleting entries	Click the X button on any entry to remove it.

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Comparing Plants Side by Side

Compare up to 4 plants in a side-by-side table. Fields that differ between plants are highlighted in yellow.

1	Click Compare mode Tick-boxes appear on cards.
	Select 2–4 plants A bar appears at the bottom.
3	Click Compare → Opens the comparison table.
	Close Click X or press Escape.

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Collections, Tags, and Saved Searches

Custom Tags	Type in the Tags field, press Enter or comma. Tags appear as purple pills on cards and can be used as a filter. Backspace removes the last tag when the field is empty.
Create collection	Click Collections → type a name → Add.
Assign collection	Edit the plant → choose a collection from the dropdown → Save.
Filter by collection	Use the Collection filter in the filter panel, or click Filter next to a name.
Delete collection	Collections panel → Delete. Plants are kept but lose their assignment.
Saved Searches	Set filters → click + Save search → type a name. Click any teal pill to restore. Click X to delete.

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Phenology Calendar

The Phenology Calendar tab shows a 12-month grid of which plants flower and fruit in each month.

Pink	Flowering only
Orange	Fruiting only
Purple	Both flowering and fruiting
Green	Year-round

Filter by Collection or Plant Type using the dropdowns at the top. Toggle Flowering and Fruiting on/off with the checkboxes. Click any coloured cell or plant name to open that plant's full profile. Click any month header to see a detail panel listing all active plants with flower colours.

■ Adding phenology data

To see plants in the calendar, add Flowering Season and/or Fruiting Period when editing a plant. Both are multi-select fields in the Botanical Characteristics section of the form.

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Dashboard, AI Descriptions, and Suitability Checker

The Dashboard tab contains three tools. Scroll down to access each.

Live Charts

Six bar charts update automatically as plants are added: Plants by Type, Climate Zones, Health Status, Weed Status, Life Expectancy, and Top Uses.

AI Plant Description Generator

Technical / Botanical	Precise horticultural and botanical terminology.
Plain English	Friendly, jargon-free language for a general audience.
Educational / Student	Accessible for secondary students with ecological emphasis.
Landscape Architect	Focuses on design application, form, and site suitability.

Select a plant and style, click Generate Description. Click Apply to Plant to save the generated text to the Description field. Always review before applying.

Suitability Checker

Enter site conditions (climate zone, aspect, soil, max height, max width, required use) and click Check Suitability. Every plant is scored 0–100%. Green ≥80% = excellent match. Amber 50–79% = good match. Red <50% = poor match. Click any result to open the plant's full profile.

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External Lookup Links and Online Databases

Every plant profile with a genus and species recorded has a  Look Up Online section near the bottom. Click the heading to expand 13 clickable links, all auto-generated from the plant's scientific name.

VicFlora	Victorian flora database from the Royal Botanic Gardens Victoria.
Atlas of Living Australia	Occurrence records, maps, and biodiversity data across Australia.
Plants of the World Online	Global flora database from the Royal Botanic Gardens, Kew.
iNaturalist	Community observations and species identification database.
Wikipedia	General encyclopaedia species page.
PlantNet ID	AI-powered photo identification and species data.
Google Lens	Google image-based plant identification.
FloraBase (WA)	Western Australian flora database from the WA Herbarium.
GBIF	Global Biodiversity Information Facility — worldwide occurrence data.
Plants of SE NSW	Lucid key to plants of South-East New South Wales.
Seeds of SA	Seeds of South Australia — germination and flora data.
Plants of Tasmania	Tasmanian flora database from the Tasmanian Museum and Art Gallery.
Queensland Flora	Queensland Government Department of Environment species search.

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Exporting Data — CSV, PDF, JSON, and Palette

Click Export above the card grid. Choose which plants (all or currently filtered) and a format:

CSV	All 40+ fields as columns. Multi-select fields semicolon-separated. Can be re-imported.
PDF — Compact	All plants as a continuous list with type/climate tags and optional thumbnails.
PDF — Detailed	One full profile per page with all fields, tags, and cover photo.
JSON	Complete backup including all photos as base64, collections, and saved searches.
Palette	Visual card grid — photo, name, type, climate, dimensions. Great for client presentations.

Single-plant export: Open any plant profile and click CSV or PDF for an instant export of just that plant.

Plant Label and QR Code

Click Label in any plant profile to generate a printable label (name, scientific name, family, type, size, climate, aspect, soil, life expectancy) alongside a QR code linking to the plant's iNaturalist page. Click Print Label or Download QR.

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Importing Data from CSV

Click Import CSV above the card grid. Drag-and-drop or browse for a CSV file. A preview of the first 8 rows appears before you confirm.

Add to existing plants	Appends imported plants to the current database.
Replace entire database	Deletes all current plants first. Use with caution.
Getting the column template	Export → CSV from your existing database first, then add rows in Excel and re-import.

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■ Cloud Sync — Google Sheets & Multi-Device

The ■ Sync tab lets you connect PlantDB to your own private Google Sheet. Once connected, your plants are accessible from any device and automatically backed up to Google Drive.

First-Time Setup

1

Get Code.gs

Download PD.zip and open Code.gs. Go to script.google.com, create a new project, paste the code, and save.

Run setupSheet

In the Apps Script editor, select setupSheet from the function dropdown and click Run. Grant permissions when prompted. This creates your Google Sheet.

3

Deploy as Web App

Click Deploy → New deployment → Web App. Execute as: Me. Who has access: Anyone. Click Deploy and copy the /exec URL.

Connect in PlantDB

Click ■ Sync in the nav bar. Paste the URL. Click Connect & Test. A green badge confirms success.

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Push your data

Click Push to Cloud to upload all local plants to the Sheet. The progress bar and log show status.

Sync Actions

Push to Cloud	Uploads all local plants to the Google Sheet. Overwrites the sheet.
Pull from Cloud	Downloads plants from the Sheet and merges with local data. Remote data wins on conflict; local-only plants are kept.
Sync Now	Flushes the pending offline queue immediately.
Open Sheet	Opens the Google Sheet directly in a new tab.

Auto-Sync Settings

Push on every save	Automatically push after every add, edit, or delete.
Pull on startup	Check for cloud updates each time the app loads.
Offline queue	Queue changes when offline and push automatically when reconnected. A yellow badge shows the number of queued changes.

Multi-Device Use

All devices use the same Apps Script URL. Make a change on one device — it pushes to the Sheet. On another device, go to ■ Sync → Pull from Cloud to receive the latest data. With "Push on every save" and "Pull on startup" both enabled, the sync is essentially automatic.

■ Optional security

Add PLANTDB_TOKEN to Apps Script Project Settings → Script Properties. Enter the same token in ■ Sync → Auth Token field. All requests without the correct token are rejected.

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Appearance Customisation

Click the  Appearance button (palette icon) in the hero area or navigation to open the three-tab Appearance panel. All settings persist across sessions.

Themes tab

Choose from 7 built-in colour themes: Default, Midnight, Desert Sand, Ocean Blue, Slate, Terracotta, and High Contrast.

Custom Colour tab

Override any of the five main accent colours individually: Nav/Header, Hero/Accent, Page Background, Leaf/Highlight, and Gold/Badge. Changes apply live. Use "Copy CSS" to export your overrides.

Layout & Text tab

Font size	Slide 12–18px. Scales all text throughout the app.
Card corner radius	Slide 0–20px. Sets the roundness of plant cards and panels.
Card density	Comfortable (default) / Compact (tighter padding) / Spacious (more breathing room).
Grid columns	Auto (responsive) or fix at 2, 3, 4, or 5 columns.
Nav style	Normal / Compact (smaller tabs) / Icons only (tabs show icon only).
Hero section	Full (default) / Mini (hides stats bar) / Hidden (hides entire hero banner).

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Installing as an App & Keyboard Shortcuts

The Plant Living Database is a Progressive Web App (PWA) — it can be installed on any device for full-screen use and offline access.

PC / Mac (Chrome or Edge)	Look for the install icon in the address bar (computer with down arrow). Click it and click Install. The app opens in its own window.
Android (Chrome)	Tap the three-dot menu → "Add to Home Screen" or "Install app" → Add.
iPhone / iPad (Safari)	Open the URL in Safari. Tap the Share button (↑) → scroll down → "Add to Home Screen" → Add. Must use Safari, not Chrome.

Keyboard Shortcuts

Escape	Close any open panel or modal.
← / → arrow keys	Navigate photos in the lightbox.
Enter	Add a tag (when cursor is in the Tags field).
Comma	Alternative to Enter for adding a tag.
Backspace	Delete last tag when the Tags field is empty and cursor is in it.

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All Data Fields Reference

Family Name	Plant family, e.g. Proteaceae.
Genus *	Scientific genus. Required (with Common Name).
Species	Species epithet.
Subspecies / Variety	Taxonomic subdivisions below species.
Cultivar	Cultivar name and variation notes.
Common Name/s *	Familiar name. Shown on card. Required (with Genus).
Height / Width (M)	In metres. Ranges accepted, e.g. 2–4.
Plant Type 1	Primary growth form: Tree, Shrub, Groundcover, Climber/Vine, Grass, Sedge, Rush, Fern, Moss/Lichen, Herb, Palm, Succulent, Bulb, Aquatic.
Plant Type 2	Life cycle: Perennial, Annual, Biennial, Evergreen, Deciduous, Semi-deciduous, Ephemeral.
Plant Type 3	Origin: Native, Exotic, Dicotyledon, Monocotyledon, Gymnosperm, Fern, Bryophyte.
Life Expectancy	≤2 years through >100 years.
Climate Type/s	Multi-select: Tropical, Sub-tropical, Warm Temperate, Cool Temperate, Mediterranean, Semi-arid, Arid, Alpine, Coastal, Savannah.
Aspect / Light	Multi-select: Full Sun through Shaded all day.
Soil / Media	Multi-select: 17 options covering texture, moisture, and pH.
Site Constraints	Multi-select: 11 infrastructure and environmental impact options.
Description	Distinguishing features, hazards, weediness, uses.
Cultural Requirements	Maintenance, establishment, climate change resilience.
References	URLs or citations (comma-separated).
Leaf Type / Shape	e.g. Simple, Compound, Linear, Lobed, Palmate.
Flower Colour	Multi-select: White, Yellow, Orange, Red, Pink, Purple, Blue, Green, Brown, Cream, Multi-coloured, Insignificant.
Flowering Season/s	Multi-select: Spring, Summer, Autumn, Winter, Year-round.
Fruit / Seed Description	e.g. Small red berry, dry capsule, winged samara.
Fruiting Period	Multi-select: same season options as flowering.
Native Region	Free text, e.g. VIC, NSW, Eastern Australia, Worldwide.
Uses	Multi-select: 20 options including Shade, Screen/Hedge, Erosion Control, Revegetation, Fire Retardant, Windbreak, Edible, and more.
Supports Wildlife	Multi-select: 11 groups from Nectar Birds to Amphibians.
Ecological Role	Multi-select: 12 ecological functions including Pollinator Support, Carbon Sequestration, Nitrogen Fixation.
Indigenous Uses / Notes	Optional, culturally appropriate free text field.

Toxic / Poisonous Parts	Dropdown (None, All parts, Leaves, Berries, Seeds, Roots, Sap/Latex, Thorns/Spines, Unknown) + notes text.
Allergen Risk	Dropdown (No known risk through Multiple allergen risks) + notes text.
Weed / Invasive Status	Not weedy, Listed monitor weed, Listed weed, Noxious weed (declared).
Plant Health Status	Good, Fair, Poor, Dead/Removed, Unknown.
GPS Coordinates	Decimal degrees, e.g. -37.8136, 144.9631.
Map Reference / Grid	For site maps, e.g. Grid B4.
Custom Tags	Freeform keywords for flexible filtering. Multiple allowed.
Notes	Private scratchpad — personal observations, not exported in some formats.
Collection	Named group this plant belongs to. One collection per plant.
Planting Log	Timestamped journal entries (Observation, Maintenance, Health Update, Planting).
Date Added	Set automatically when the plant record is first saved.
Date Modified	Updated automatically on every edit.